

SOUND WAVES, ONCE produced, do not really perish. Acousticians tell us that, unless met by an equal and opposite wave, a sonic disturbance of the air only loses amplitude, becomes inaudible, but lingers out there—bouncing off the walls of the universe like a tape on loop. It might have been handy for music historians to be able to listen in on what was being sung in 17th-century Tanjore, or by Sultan Hussain Shah Sharqi as he relaxed in the chhattri above his hamaam in 15th c Jaunpur, or what Matanga muni heard in the Deccan countryside centuries earlier. Presently, they are forced to stitch together a picture of our aural history from fragmentary pieces of text. But any future machine would have it much easier picking up an unholy commotion that disturbed the March air in 2024. As the soft, self-contained world of Carnatic music went into crescendos of rage and spleen, the amplitudes seemed loud enough to rattle the doors of history for a while. Sounds of rupture but also, perchance, after the dust settles, of evolution.

A brief recap for those who came late into the auditorium: on March 18, the Madras Music Academy conferred the Sangita Kalanidhi award, the highest honour in Carnatic, on vocalist T.M. Krishna. On musical grounds, no one would have dreamt of objecting: he has long been seen as one of the dyad that defines the new generation, along with Sanjay Subrahmaniam. A sensitive interpreter of the canon, with notes of honey and a virtuosic temper realised through melodic rather than gymnastic means, at age 48 he is in fact quite the late recipient. But what erupted all around was a pack howl of indignation, as if something sacred had been defiled. The vocalist-violinist sisters Ranjani-Gayatri withdrew from the next Music Academy Conference. Krishna has spread "a sense of shame in being a Carnatic musician...through his consistent denigration of spirituality in music. It is dangerous to overlook (his) glorification of a figure like EVR," they wrote on social media, alluding to his 2023 performance of *Sindikka Chonnavar Periyar*, casting the Dravidian ideologue as the one "Who Made Us Think". They said he had "insulted icons" like Thyagaraja and M.S. Subbulakshmi with his caste analysis. The Trichur Brothers followed, invoking his "extremely divisive narrative". Chitravina N. Ravikiran returned his Kalanidhi award. "History does not speak well of Jaichands and Mir Jafars," wrote critic Renuka Narayanan. Since Carnatic marks off a global cohort where everyone comes with a deep sense of ownership, opinions were in spate.

What sparked off this sonic boom? Well, Krishna is not just another flawless conduit of tradition. From his early days of perfect conformity, with the Iyengar *namam* intact on his forehead, he grew into a phase of interrogation, and reached for something be-



"Krishna's interventions are crucial because they gesture back at well-documented historical fact. The idea that Carnatic is 'pure' or a bulwark against 'foreign' influences from the North, Persia, or anywhere else has never been true"

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